pressure from Pakistan, notwithstanding Mullah Omar's declaration that the Taliban will attend the meeting only if it is recognised as the legitimate government of Afghanistan.[41] Soon after the creation of 6+2, Pakistan offered a peace deal to the UF, only to be rejected by the latter. The UF, despite being militarily hard-pressed, had few reasons to give tactical diplomatic space to the Taliban. Pakistan itself had become heavily isolated and was losing clout in wake of the 1998 Chagai nuclear tests. India, on the other hand, was actively lobbying Washington with Vajpayee calling the US a 'natural ally' soon after the Pokharan nuclear tests.[42] Secondly, regardless of Indian concerns about being actively excluded from the 6+2, the UN did engage with India on the Afghan question throughout this period. A twelve-member UN delegation visited New Delhi in May 2001 to assess the feasibility of economic sanctions against the Taliban. While India was happy with the sanctions arrangement, Pakistani President Musharraf refused to cooperate. Much like the 6+2, which failed under its own weight, no economic sanctions on the Taliban would have much impact if Pakistan did not desire them.

Thirdly, the US was getting increasingly frustrated with Pakistan's non-cooperation in the 6+2. In March 1999, US Assistant Secretary of State on South Asia, Karl Inderfurth, confided his vexation with Pakistan's obstinate support to the Taliban to Secretary of State Madeleine Albright. US efforts, he mentioned,

> will have to shift away from trying to work with Pakistan, and to a lesser extent with Iran, in the 6+2 toward bringing greater pressure on Pakistan and Iran. We will look to Russia to support this process particularly with Iran. We may have to move from a 6+2 process to a Eight Minus One process, emphasising the isolation of Pakistan.'[43] If this eight minus one framework also failed then, 'another stick we [US] might think of using on Pakistan is the idea of expanding the Six Plus Two to include other Central Asian states and India, a move that Pakistan would oppose.[44]

As these cables demonstrate, the US had come a long way from being supportive of Pakistan, and the six plus two played a role in shaping this opinion.

As India expected, the process failed. According to a detailed, unpublished, report prepared for the British government, a close advisor of the Taliban leadership stated that the six plus two meetings were convened on false pretences. 'Uzbekistan had informed Mullah Omar that Rabbani was willing to surrender, and that he wanted to discuss this in Uzbekistan. The UF had meanwhile been informed that the Taliban were ready to make a deal'.[45] As one attendee of the